

ISAAC D. MEHLHAFF

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Updated: July 27, 2026
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ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

The University of Chicago

Neubauer Family Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science	2025 -
Faculty Member, Committee on Data Science	2025 -
Faculty Affiliate, Chicago Center for Computational Social Science	2025 -
Faculty Affiliate, Data Science Institute	2025 -
Faculty Affiliate, Program in Political Economy	2025 -
Postdoctoral Scholar, Data Science Institute	2023 - 2024

Texas A&M University

Assistant Professor, Department of Political Science	2024 - 2025
Research Affiliate, Institute of Data Science	2024 - 2025

Institut d'études politiques de Paris

Visiting Scholar, AxPo Observatory of Market Society Polarization	2025
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EDUCATION

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Doctor of Philosophy in Political Science	2023
Master of Arts in Political Science	2020

University of Wisconsin-Madison

Bachelor of Arts with Honors in the Liberal Arts	2018
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BOOK

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. *Mass Polarization across Time and Space*. New York: Cambridge University Press, Elements in Comparative Political Behavior. 2025.

PEER-REVIEWED JOURNAL ARTICLES

Marc J. Hetherington, Andrew M. Engelhardt, and **Isaac D. Mehlhaff**. "More Than a Partisan Pandemic: Worldview and COVID-19 Response in the United States." *Advances in Political Psychology* 47, no. S1 (December 2026): e70125.

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. "A Group-Based Approach to Measuring Polarization." *American Political Science Review* 118, no. 3 (August 2024): 1518-1526.

Isaac D. Mehlhaff, Matías C. Tarillo, Ayelén Vanegas, and Marc J. Hetherington. "Partisanship and the Pandemic: How and Why Americans Followed Party Cues on COVID-19." *Journal of Health Politics, Policy, and Law* 49, no. 3 (June 2024): 351-374.

Isaac D. Mehlhaff, Timothy J. Ryan, Marc J. Hetherington, and Michael B. MacKuen. "Where Motivated Reasoning Withers and Looms Large: Fear and Partisan Reactions to the COVID-19 Pandemic." *American Journal of Political Science* 68, no. 1 (January 2024): 5-23.

Sam Schmitt, **Isaac D. Mehlhaff**, and Emily Cottle Ommundsen. "Integrating Classroom and Community with Undergraduate Civically Engaged Research." *PS: Political Science and Politics* 56, no. 4 (October 2023): 469-474.

PEER-REVIEWED CONFERENCE PROCEEDINGS

Amirhossein Farzam, Shashank Shekhar, **Isaac D. Mehlhaff**, and Marco Morucci. “Multi-Task Learning Improves Performance in Deep Argument Mining Models.” *Proceedings of the 11th Workshop on Argument Mining*, Association for Computational Linguistics (August 2024): 46-58.

UNDER REVIEW

Robert C. Luskin, Daron R. Shaw, Marc J. Hetherington, and **Isaac D. Mehlhaff**. “Do Political Factors Help Explain Partisan Bias in Polling? An Examination of Signed Forecast Errors in Pre-Election Media Surveys.”

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. “Mass Polarization and Democratic Decline: Evidence from a Half-Century of Public Opinion.”

İrem Betül Koçak, **Isaac D. Mehlhaff**, and Başak Taraktaş. “When Talk is Not Enough: Social Context and the Persistence of Ideological Polarization.”

Kevin J. Angell and **Isaac D. Mehlhaff**. “Talking Politics on the Job: How Corporate Activism Shapes Political Participation.”

WORK IN PROGRESS

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. *The Persuasive Citizen: How Political Debate Can Change Minds and Heal Divides*.

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. “Political Argumentation and Attitude Change in Online Interactions.”

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. “How Executive Institutions Shape Affective Polarization: Evidence from Israel, 1975-2001.”

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. “Leveraging Time-Series Information to Improve Small-Area Estimation.”

Isaac D. Mehlhaff, Molly Offer-Westort, and Nick Feamster. “Interpersonal Discussion and Persuasion in Political Settings.”

Marc S. Jacob and **Isaac D. Mehlhaff**. “Reconsidering the Polarization and Democracy Nexus: Concepts, Causation, and Conditioning Factors.”

Amirhossein Farzam, **Isaac D. Mehlhaff**, and Marco Morucci. “Multi-Task Learning in Social Scientific Applications.”

SOFTWARE

Isaac D. Mehlhaff, Marco Morucci, Josephine Ginting, and Eddie Ye Tian. **multitask**: A Flexible Multi-Task Learning Library for NLP (version 1.1.0). *Python Package Index*.
<https://pypi.org/project/multitask-py/>.

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. **PolarCAP**: Access the Polarization in Comparative Attitudes Project (version 1.1.0). *Comprehensive R Archive Network*. <https://cran.r-project.org/package=PolarCAP>.

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. **CPC**: Implementation of Cluster-Polarization Coefficient (version 2.6.0). *Comprehensive R Archive Network*. <https://cran.r-project.org/package=CPC>.

OTHER WRITING

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. “Does Political Polarization Really Undermine Democracy? Maybe Not.” *The University of Chicago Data Science Blog* (July 29, 2024).

Marc J. Hetherington and **Isaac D. Mehlhaff**. “American attitudes toward covid-19 are divided by party. The pandemic itself might undo that.” *The Washington Post* (August 18, 2020).

Isaac D. Mehlhaff. “Subverting Solidarity: The Role of American Organized Labor in Pursuing United States Foreign Policy Objectives in Chile, 1961-1973.” *The Burkhardt Review* 1, no. 2 (2018): 24-40.

FUNDING

National Science Foundation

Graduate Research Fellowship, \$138,000 2020 - 2023

Society for Political Methodology

Travel Award, \$1,650 2023

Midwest Political Science Association

Pi Sigma Alpha Travel Award, \$500 2023

American Political Science Association

Centennial Center Research Grant, \$2,400 2022

Travel Award, \$150 2022

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Graduate Fellowship, Program for Public Discourse, \$1,000 2021 - 2022

Americas Graduate Fellowship, Institute for the Study of the Americas, \$5,000 2018 - 2020

Uhlman Research Grant, Department of Political Science, \$2,000 2019

European Consortium for Political Research

Travel Award, €150 2019

HONORS AND AWARDS

The University of Chicago

Neubauer Family Assistant Professorship 2025

American Political Science Association

Honorable Mention, Best Dissertation in Political Psychology 2024

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Dean's Distinguished Dissertation Award in the Social Sciences 2024

James W. Prothro Award for Best Master's Thesis in Political Science 2021

Associate Level of Accomplishment, Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching, and Learning 2021

University of Wisconsin-Madison

William Jennings Bryan Award for Best Thesis in Political Science 2018

William F. Allen Research Award, Department of History 2017

Phi Beta Kappa, College of Letters and Science 2017

INVITED TALKS AND WORKSHOPS

University of Notre Dame, Kellogg Institute for International Studies 2026

The University of Chicago Francis and Rose Yuen Campus in Hong Kong,
New Horizons for AI Research in the Social Sciences and Humanities

The University of Chicago, Computational Social Science Workshop 2025

Institut d'études politiques de Paris, Centre for Political Research

Yale University, Generative Artificial Intelligence and Sociology Workshop 2024

Texas A&M University, Department of Political Science

The University of Chicago, Quantitative Methods Workshop 2023

The University of Chicago, American Politics Workshop

University of California, Los Angeles, Politics and Computational Social Science Conference

The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, American Politics Research Group 2022

Rice University, Southern Workshop in Empirical Political Science

European University Institute, Conference on Contemporary Divides in Western Societies 2021

European Consortium for Political Research, Standing Group on Latin American Politics 2019

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Annual Conference on Elections, Public Opinion, and Voting Behavior	2026
Annual Meeting of the American Political Science Association	2021 - 2026
Annual Conference of the Midwest Political Science Association	2022 - 2026
Keeping the Republic Conference, University of Notre Dame	2024
Association for Computational Linguistics, Workshop on Argument Mining	2024
Annual Conference of the Society for Political Methodology	2020, 2022 - 2024
Annual Meeting of the Southern Political Science Association	2021

TEACHING

The University of Chicago

SOSC 13300: Social Science Inquiry III	2026 - 2027
PLSC/DATA 40501: Machine Learning in the Social Sciences	2026
PLSC 20150: The Art of Productive Political Debate	2026
PLSC 30500: Introduction to Quantitative Social Science	2025 - 2026
PLSC 49999: Math Camp (Faculty Supervisor)	2025 - 2026
Data Science Clinic, Data Science Institute (Project Mentor)	2023 - 2024

Texas A&M University

POLS 309: Polimetrics	2024
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The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

POLI 276: Everyday Political Theory: Seeing Like a Citizen (Graduate Consultant)	2022
Agora Fellows, Program for Public Discourse (Facilitator)	2021
POLI 203: Race, Innocence, and the End of the Death Penalty (Teaching Assistant)	2020
POLI 100: American Democracy in Changing Times (Teaching Assistant)	2019
POLI 208: Political Parties and Elections (Instructional Assistant)	2018

ADVISING

Cemal Yilmaz, PhD, Political Science	Ongoing	Egemen Aray, MA, Social Sciences	2026
Ella Storms, BA/MA, Political Science		Sylvia Dou, MA, Social Sciences	
Ilana Gellman, BA Honors, Political Science		Ye Tian, MA, Computational Social Science	
		Xuan Qu, MA, Social Sciences	

SERVICE

The University of Chicago

Member, Quantitative Methods Search Committee	2025 - 2026
Member, Data Science Joint PhD Committee	2025 - 2026

American Political Science Association

Mentor, Early Career Fellows Program; Elections, Public Opinion, and Voting Behavior Section	2025 - 2026
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Texas A&M University

Member, Graduate Admissions Committee	2024 - 2025
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The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

Graduate Student President, Department of Political Science	2022 - 2023
Coordinator, Formal and Quantitative Seminar	2022 - 2023
Committee Member, Charles Robson Award for Excellence in Graduate Instruction	2022 - 2023
Member, Removing Inequities in Political Science Working Group	2020 - 2023
Member, Graduate Stipends Committee	2020 - 2021
Coordinator, UNC-Duke Working Group on Latin American Politics	2019 - 2020

Discussant

Virtual Workshop Series, Polarization Consortium	2025
Large Language Models Workshop, European Political Science Association	2025
Annual Meeting of the American Political Science Association	2024 - 2025
Annual Conference of the Midwest Political Science Association	2025 - 2026
Annual Conference of the Society for Political Methodology	2024 - 2026

American Politics Research Group, The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill	2023
Workshop on Latin American Politics and Party Competition, Duke University	2021
Standing Group on Latin American Politics, European Consortium for Political Research	2019

Reviewer

American Journal of Political Science, American Political Science Review, APSA Centennial Center, British Journal of Political Science, Electoral Studies, IEEE Transactions on Network Science and Engineering, The Journal of Politics, NSF GRFP Peer Review Workshop, Perspectives on Politics, Political Analysis, Political Behavior, Political Communication, Political Psychology, Political Science Research and Methods, Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, PS: Political Science and Politics, Public Opinion Quarterly, Social Science Computer Review, The Social Science Journal, Spatial Demography, Time-Sharing Experiments for the Social Sciences